

PLANETARY SYSTEMS

Our planet Earth and its seven sister planets make up the Solar System. For centuries it was the only planetary system known to astronomers. In the past couple of decades, though, they have found hundreds of planetary systems around other stars. They have all formed from the whirling disc of gas and dust that surrounded their parent star when it was still a protostar – a star still in its early stage of formation.

About 117 light years away from us, the star Kepler-444 is similar to the Sun in its size and brightness, but is more than twice as old

DATA FILE



NUMBER OF KNOWN STARS WITH AT LEAST ONE PLANET: 2,571



NUMBER OF MULTIPLE PLANET SYSTEMS: 585



SYSTEM WITH MOST PLANETS: HD 10180, 7 (confirmed), possibly 9



CLOSEST PLANETARY SYSTEM: Gliese 876, 4 planets, 15 light years away